

Speaking Exercise: Discussion in Pairs

English for Professional Purposes-II (BELH0021)

GLA University

Speaking Exercise: Discussion in Pairs

Pair discussions involve two learners engaging in a structured conversation on a given topic. This approach is particularly effective for ESL and placement exams as it offers a dynamic and interactive way to assess speaking proficiency.

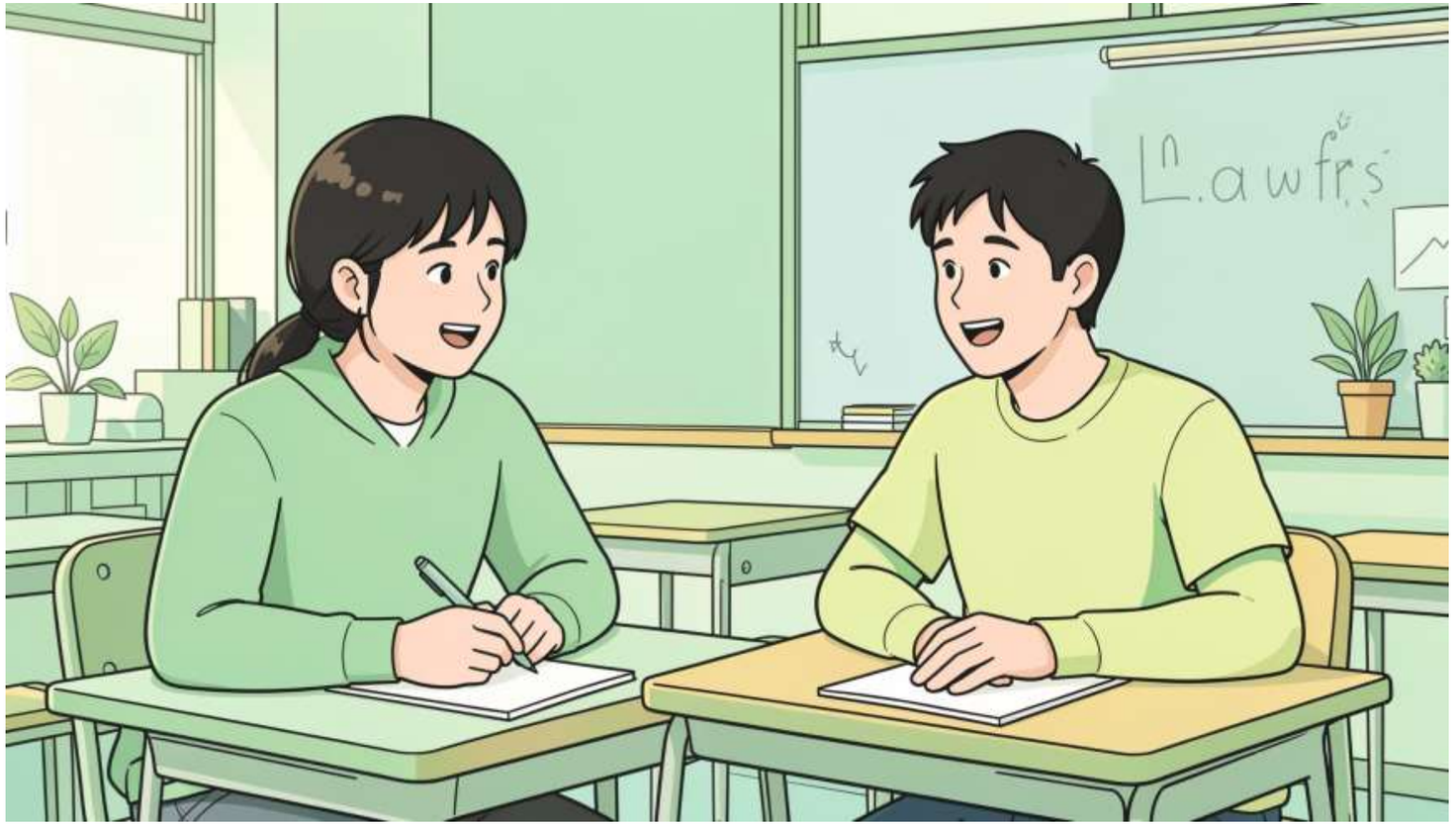
They are highly beneficial because they:

- Build confidence
- Encourage active listening
- Develop communication skills
- Provide low-pressure practice before high-stakes assessments

ACTIVITY:1

The "Hook": Active Listening from the Start

In the "Blind Summary" activity, one learner shares a professional achievement, and their partner must then introduce them to the class in 30 seconds. This immediately immerses learners in active listening and concise communication.



ACTIVITY: 2

Speed Discussion Rounds

Dynamic Rotation Speaking Activity

Activity Structure

Formation

Two circles:

- Inner Circle → Stays stationary
- Outer Circle → Rotates after each round

Students stand face-to-face

Rounds

- 3 minutes per round

New topic in each round

Outer circle rotates clockwise after every round

Round 1 – Express & Explain

- State your opinion
- Give one reason
- Provide one example

Focus: Fluency & clarity

Round 2 – Extend & Respond

- React to your partner’s view
- Add support or contrast
- Ask one follow-up question

Focus: Interaction & active listening

Round 3 – Diplomatic Disagreement

Rule: You Must Disagree Politely

Even if you agree, take the opposite position.

Use diplomatic language:

- "I understand your point, however…"
- "That's a valid view, but I see it differently…"
- "With due respect, I would argue that…"

Focus:

- Professional tone
- Logical reasoning
- Emotional control

Interactive Activity 3: Topic Debate Challenge

This activity sharpens critical thinking and persuasive communication by challenging students to argue both sides of a contentious issue. It fosters adaptability and deep understanding of complex topics.

Topic Presentation

A controversial, real-world topic is introduced to the class.

Argument Development

Students are assigned a side (for/against) and given time to research and build arguments.

Debate Rounds

Pairs engage in structured debate, presenting opening statements and rebuttals.

Perspective Shift

Students reverse roles, arguing the opposite side to deepen empathy and understanding.

Constructive Feedback

Peers provide feedback on argument strength, delivery, and diplomatic communication.

Interactive Activity 4: Scenario Role-Play

This activity places students in simulated professional environments, challenging them to apply their English communication skills in practical, real-world workplace scenarios. It builds confidence in navigating difficult conversations, negotiations, and client interactions, making it ideal for ESL learners preparing for the professional world.

Scenario Briefing

Students receive a detailed brief outlining a common workplace challenge or opportunity.

Role Assignment

Each student is assigned a specific professional role (e.g., client, manager, colleague) with clear objectives.

Role-Play Execution

Pairs or small groups act out the scenario, improvising dialogue and problem-solving.

Feedback & Reflection

Participants and observers provide constructive feedback on communication effectiveness and strategy.

Language Focus

The instructor highlights key vocabulary, phrases, and diplomatic expressions used effectively during the role-play.

Thank you !